

“A little bit...”

Simplicity and humility, or... No hidden agendas! Just honesty.

The Orthodox Christian faith is full of life-giving truth, but it is also very complex and even overwhelming to beginners. It is not at all like the typical Western expression of Christianity, and this is part of the reason why it is so overwhelming and seems too big to many people. These small postings are in attempt to give “A Little Bit” of knowledge and edification regarding Orthodox Christianity. Since they come from my mind, they are not necessarily organized, but they are absolutely from the heart. It may be very hard to learn all the fasting rules and to go to long services and to read the Fathers, or even the Bible, but it is not so hard to read or listen to or watch a short video about something that is just “A Little Bit” about Christianity. [Priest Seraphim Holland](#), who is learning a little bit each day about how to be a real Christian.

Let all of us who wish to attract the Lord to ourselves draw near to Him as disciples to the Master, simply, without hypocrisy, without duplicity or guile, not out of idle curiosity. He Himself is simple and absolute, and He wants souls that come to Him to be simple and innocent. For you will surely never see simplicity separated from humility. (The Ladder of Divine Ascent Step 24.26)

This quote from the “Ladder of Divine Ascent” by John Climacus (this book is traditionally read by many people during Great Lent) might seem to be complicated but it is actually expressing a very simple truth. Reading spiritual things is hard and takes experience. When the meaning of the spiritual text is pointed out to us, we can often understand it without extensive spiritual experience, because we have our own experience.

Do we like fake people? No, absolutely not! If a person does not seem to be authentic we dismiss them. God also does this with our prayers. If we are not authentic, God will dismiss them. Perhaps this seems harsh to some people, but it is the simple truth. There is lots of Scripture that supports this truth¹, but even if we don’t know the Scripture, we know from our own experience that those with hidden agendas and those who do not say what they mean and mean what they say are not to be trusted.

We are called to be like God and God is simple and always honest. God is also pure and holy. We cannot be pure and holy, because we sin, but we can be simple and honest. Which is easier? It easier to be holy and perfect, or is it easier to be honest with others and even with ourselves? Of course, the latter is easier, although in our modern society that does not like the truth about ourselves it is still very hard.

This is why I love Great Lent. It is a time when our services tell the truth about ourselves. It is very cathartic to admit, whether in a prayer that we say in the church, or even better, when we are praying alone, that we are sinners and we cannot do what is right without God helping us in everything. There is power in that kind of humility.

Do not be so concerned with whether or not you sin. Of course, you sin! Perhaps some of your sins are even terrible. There are those in life have sinned more terribly than you, but their humility (which is always accompanied with repentance) attracted grace of God and the fragrance of holiness, and they have found their way and achieved union with God.

Since you can never be “good enough”, it is better to know that you are not good but that God loves you and will help you. This idea is present in all of Orthodox spirituality. It is not present in modern philosophy and life experience.

How can we apply simplicity and humility to our lives in a practical way? We are simple if we always try to see the best in people and never speak ill of them. We are even more simple if we never think ill of them, but God will see our effort to be simple if we never slander them with our words even though our thoughts are not quite right. We are simple and humble if we don’t try to take credit or be the center of attention at our work, or any activity. We are simple and humble if we never do something with a false hidden agenda. It is possible to be simple in these ways. If we are simple outwardly God will see our effort and he will help us to be simple inwardly. This is a fundamental spiritual truth that is well understood in Orthodox spirituality. It is the Christian way of life, that is, the only way that leads to eternal life.

This has been just “a little bit” about simplicity and humility. 3/20/2018

<http://www.orthodox.net/a-little-bit/alb-simplicity-and-humility-and-no-hidden-agendas.doc>

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Tags: A Little bit, Simplicity, Humility, Ladder of Divine Ascent, Prayer-During Great Lent

¹ For instance: James 1:5-8 “If any of you lack wisdom, let him ask of God, that giveth to all men liberally, and upbraideth not; and it shall be given him. (6) But let him ask in faith, nothing wavering. For he that wavereth is like a wave of the sea driven with the wind and tossed. (7) For let not that man think that he shall receive any thing of the Lord. (8) A double minded man is unstable in all his ways.”